

Prior Authorization Criteria - MRI Studies

Policy Overview

This document describes the prior authorization criteria for Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) studies under the SynthHealth Insurance plan. All criteria below must be satisfied for prior authorization to be approved.

Effective date: January 1, 2026

Applicable CPT codes: 72141, 72146, 72148, 72156, 72158

Criterion 1: Documented Diagnosis

The requesting physician must provide a clearly documented primary diagnosis with ICD-10 code consistent with the MRI study being requested.

Criterion 2: Conservative Treatment Trial

The member must have completed a minimum of 6 weeks of conservative treatment prior to requesting advanced imaging. Acceptable treatments include: physical therapy, chiropractic care, oral analgesics, or injection therapy. Documentation of the treatment course and clinical response is required.

Criterion 3: No Recent Equivalent Imaging

An equivalent MRI study of the same anatomical region must not have been performed within the preceding 12 months. If a prior MRI exists, clinical documentation must explain why a new study is required.

Criterion 4: Clinical Symptom Documentation

The member's medical record must include documented clinical findings such as: pain severity scores, functional limitation assessment, neurological findings, or objective test results (e.g., EMG, X-ray).

Criterion 5: Ordering Physician

The MRI must be ordered by the member's treating physician or a specialist to whom the member has been referred. Orders from non-treating physicians will not satisfy this criterion.

Approval and Denial

If all five criteria are met, prior authorization will be APPROVED.

If one or more criteria are not met or documentation is insufficient, the request will be DENIED or PENDED pending additional documentation.

Members and providers may appeal denied authorizations within 30 days.